

Nominal placeholders in Southern Cone Spanish: an explorative discussion on Rioplatense *coso* and Chilean *este/esta**

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Abstract

This paper examines the grammatical behavior of two nominal placeholders in Latin American Spanish: *coso* in Rioplatense Spanish and *este/esta* in Chilean Spanish. These expressions function as substitutes for nouns that are forgotten or deliberately left unmentioned. Drawing on novel data, I show that both elements systematically give rise to interpretations involving epistemic specificity, a property that distinguishes them from general nouns such as *cosa* ‘thing’. At the same time, they differ with respect to a number of morphosyntactic properties. To account for these contrasts, I propose an analysis according to which *coso* is a noun that incorporates into a specificity projection within the nominal structure, while *este/esta* is a demonstrative modifier accompanying a phonologically empty noun. This analysis shows that nominal placeholders do not form a uniform grammatical class; rather, their varying properties emerge from the interaction of lexical and morphosyntactic factors.

Keywords— Chilean Spanish, Rioplatense Spanish, placeholders, nominal syntax, microvariation

1 Introducción

A *placeholder* is an element that occupies a syntactic position corresponding to a lexical expression that the speaker either does not remember or prefers not to pronounce (Podlesskaya 2010, Vogel 2020, Seraku 2022). In this study, I will specifically refer to nominal placeholders, i.e., elements that take the place of a nominal expression. Examples (1) to (3) illustrate the functioning of nominal placeholders: as shown, the words *whatchamacallit* in English, *machin* in French, and *Dingsbums* in German allow a speaker to refer to a specific thing or person that is not mentioned explicitly but is assumed to be identifiable by the listener.

- (1) I ran into whatchamacallit at the store yesterday.

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- (2) Je dois aller chercher mon machin chez le réparateur.
I must go pick.up my MACHIN at the repair.shop
'I have to pick up my whatchamacallit from the repair shop.'
- (3) Ich habe gestern mein Dingsbums im Büro vergessen.
I have yesterday my DINGSBUMS in office forgotten
'Yesterday I forgot my whatchamacallit at the office.'

The phenomenon is not exclusive to these languages. Similar uses are observed in many Spanish varieties. As discussed by Mihatsch (2024), Peninsular Spanish exhibits the form *chisme* as a nominal placeholder, e.g., (4); the *Diccionario Panhispánico de Dudas* (DPD) reports that the pronominal form *esto* is used in Peru "as a noun when the name of an object is forgotten," e.g., (5); in Mexico, the apparent combination of a demonstrative and the partitive *de* results in forms such as *deste* or *desa*, which can replace a noun, e.g., (6).

- (4) Había un chisme grande.
was.3SG a CHISME big
'There was a big whatchamacallit.'
- (5) Necesito un esto de color más oscuro.
need.1SG a ESTO of color more obscure
'I need a darker whatchamacallit.'
- (6) Pásame el deste que está abajo de la desta.
pass.me.2SG the DESTA that is.3SG under of the DESTA
'Pass me the whatchamacallit that is under the thingy.'¹

The linguistic study of placeholders is a relatively recent area of research, and their grammatical characteristics have yet to be explored. To begin with, a surface inspection of the examples in (1) to (6) suggests an analysis according to which nominal placeholders are simple nominal heads that do not differ significantly from other nouns in their morphosyntactic properties. Under this view, their functioning as placeholders would have to be derived from their intrinsic lexical properties and nothing else. This is, in fact, the implicit posture that many times seems to be adopted in the literature, as evidenced by the various terms used to refer to these elements, e.g., *dummy nouns* (Channell 1994), or *filler nouns* (Amiridze 2010).

In this paper, I argue that the behavior of nominal placeholders cannot be reduced to the idiosyncratic properties of certain lexical items; instead, it results from the underlying morphosyntactic representation in which these elements are introduced. I base this hypothesis on the comparative study of two nominal placeholders in Latin American Spanish that have not been previously documented in the literature: the expression *coso*, characteristic of Rioplatense Spanish, e.g., (7), and the form *este/esta*, found in Chilean Spanish, e.g., (8). These elements are functionally and semantically equivalent: they express the same type of meaning as the nominal placeholders in the examples from (1) to (6).²

¹Source: https://www.tiktok.com/@renpc_/video/7147870042808503557.

²The Rioplatense Spanish data presented in this study come from acceptability judgments provided by the author. The Chilean Spanish data likewise come from acceptability judgments collected in a classroom context with young speakers (approximately 18–21 years old), mostly from the city of Valdivia. In addition, the Chilean data were discussed with native-speaker linguists of this variety.

- (7) a. No encuentro el coso.
not find.1SG the coso
'I can't find the whatchamacallit.'
- b. Coso me dio un regalo.
coso me gave.3SG a present
'Whatchamacallit gave me a present.'
- (8) a. No encuentro el este.
not find.1SG the ESTE
'I can't find the whatchamacallit.'
- b. El este me dio un regalo.
the ESTE me gave.3SG a present
'Whatchamacallit gave me a present.'

This study aims to show two things. First, that nominal placeholders exhibit defining grammatical properties that distinguish them from, for example, common nouns with nonspecific reference such as *cosa* ('thing'). Second, it attempts to demonstrate that while the nominal placeholders *coso* and *este/esta* do share certain properties, they also display notable morphosyntactic differences. This shows that nominal placeholders do not constitute a homogeneous class of grammatical constructs. Specifically, I argue that the contrast in the morphosyntactic behavior of *coso* in Rioplatense Spanish and *este/esta* in Chilean Spanish arises from the fact that the former is a "true" nominal placeholder in the sense that *coso* is an actual noun serving as the head of an NP, whereas *este/esta* is a demonstrative modifier accompanying empty noun, which, in turn, acts as the nominal head in the construction.

The structure of the paper is as follows. Section 2 demonstrates that the nominal placeholders *coso* and *este/esta* exhibit properties that set them apart from superficially similar lexical items in the language; in particular, it shows that both elements display a sort of *epistemic specificity* in their interpretation. Section 3 contrasts the morphosyntactic behavior of *coso*, on the one hand, and *este/esta*, on the other. Section 4 presents preliminary syntactic analysis of both forms. Finally, Section 5 provides the conclusions.

2 Some distinctive properties of nominal placeholders

Podlesskaya (2010) argues that nominal placeholders generally originate from semantically vacuous nouns and third-person pronouns. This generalization seemingly holds for *coso* in Rioplatense Spanish and *este/esta* in Chilean Spanish: the former appears to be related to the noun *cosa* 'thing', while the latter takes the form of a proximal demonstrative. In this sense, it seems plausible to attribute the placeholder use of these elements to the intrinsic properties of their source forms, i.e., perhaps *coso* and *este/esta* might function as placeholders as an extension of the lexical meaning of the General Spanish words *cosa* and *este/esta*. However, as will be shown below, this idea is ultimately untenable, at least in its simplest form.

I will begin with what I take to be the simplest case: the behavior of the placeholder *este/esta* in (9b) does not seem to align with that of the DP headed by a proximal demonstrative in (9a).

- (9) a. Compré este.
bought.3SG this
'I bought this one.'

- b. Compré el este.
bought.3SG the ESTE
'I bought the whatchamacallit.'

This becomes evident when considering the distribution of possible readings for *este/esta* in the dialect: only the pattern in (9b) can be interpreted as a nominal placeholder. In general, any sentence in which the demonstrative modifier *este/esta* appears without a preceding determiner must be interpreted in Chilean Spanish strictly in deictic or anaphoric terms, i.e., as a canonical demonstrative. However, when *este/esta* directly combines with a determiner, it invariably receives a nominal placeholder reading. Crucially, the possibility of interpreting these nominals as placeholders does not seem to depend on the article they combine with, but rather on the structure in which they are embedded. For instance, both noun phrases in (10) receive a placeholder reading, regardless of whether they are definite or indefinite.

- (10) a. Pása-me [DP la esta].
pass.2SG-me the ESTA
'Give me the whatchamacallit.'
- b. Pása-me [DP una esta].
pass.2SG-me a ESTA
'Give me a whatchamacallit.'

Similarly, none of the DPs in (10) can be interpreted as a regular demonstrative element, i.e., as merely referring to an object that is near in space, time, or discourse. This becomes evident both in contrastive contexts where a demonstrative is used to pick out one entity among a salient set, and in ordinary anaphoric uses of demonstratives. First, as shown in the dialogue in (11), speakers of the Chilean dialect reject sentences in which *este/esta* appears together with a determiner in contexts where a demonstrative is expected.

- (11) A: ¿Cuál de estos compraste?
which of these bought.2SG
'Which of these did you buy?'
- B: Compré (#el) este.
bought.1SG the this
'I bought this one.'

Second, the contrast in (12) shows that while bare *este* can be used anaphorically to refer back to a previously mentioned individual, the pattern with the definite article is unacceptable in the same anaphoric setting.

- (12) a. Eliana se reunió con Jorge_i. Este_i le dijo que...
Eliana SE met3SG with Jorge this 3SG.DAT said.3SG that
'Eliana met with Jorge. This (person) told her that...'
- b. Eliana se reunió con Jorge_i. El este_{*i/j} le dijo que...
Eliana SE met3SG with Jorge the ESTE 3SG.DAT said.3SG that
'Eliana met Jorge. Whatchamacallit told her that...'

As these examples show, the functionality of the nominal placeholder *este/esta* distinguishes it from the proximal demonstrative *este/esta*. In principle, there are two possible ways of accounting for this: either

the placeholder and the demonstrative are distinct lexical items with identical form, or the placeholder reading arises when the demonstrative appears in a specific grammatical structure involving a determiner. Notice, however, that under the latter approach, one must still explain how the placeholder interpretation is derived.

Regarding *coso*, Conde (2013: 92) identifies this term as one of many lexical borrowings from Tuscan and “standard” Italian that became part of Lunfardo and, later, Rioplatense Spanish.³ The definition of *coso* provided by Lunfardo dictionaries perfectly captures the current use of this term in Rioplatense Spanish. The *Diccionario de voces lunfardas y vulgares* (Casullo 1964, my translation) defines it as “a word used interchangeably to refer to a person, an animal, or any object whose name is unknown or not remembered,” while the *Diccionario etimológico del lunfardo* (Conde 2004, my translation) states that the term refers to an “unnamed object” or an “unnamed subject”; both sources highlight the Italian origin of the term. In fact, modern Italian dictionaries offer the same definition. For example, the *Vocabolario Treccani* (Simone 2010, my translation) defines *coso* as “a colloquial term used to refer to objects whose name is unknown, not remembered at the moment, or intentionally not mentioned” that “can also be used to refer to a person.” The following sentences illustrate the use of *coso* in contemporary Italian.

- (13) a. Dammi il coso
give.me the coso
‘Give me the whatchamacallit.’
b. Ieri ho visto Coso.
yesterday have seen coso
‘I saw Whatchamacallit yesterday.’

As already mentioned, the placeholder *coso* seems to be transparently linked to the noun *cosa* ‘thing’. As shown in the pair in (14), both elements allow to refer to a certain entity in an imprecise manner. In fact, authors such as Núñez Pertejo (2018) and Seraku (2022) classify *cosa* ‘thing’ as a nominal placeholder in Spanish.

- (14) a. Compré una cosa.
bought.1sg a thing
‘I bought a thing.’
b. Compré un coso.
bought.1sg a coso
‘I bought a whatchamacallit.’

However, a closer comparison between *cosa* ‘thing’ and *coso* reveals that the former does not really behave as a nominal placeholder, but rather appears to belong to a different class of nouns with imprecise reference: the so-called *general nouns* (Halliday & Hasan 1976, Benninghoven 2018). Halliday & Hasan (1976: 274) define this class as “a small set of nouns having generalized reference within the major noun classes”. As discussed by Halliday & Hasan (1976) and Benninghoven (2018), general nouns are superordinate terms that contribute to textual cohesion by allowing anaphoric reference to a preceding

³Lunfardo is a slang that originated in the 19th century in the Río de la Plata region. It emerges from the mix of languages and dialects of European immigrants, mainly Italians, with influences of Spanish, African languages, and American-Indigenous languages. Conde (2013: 81, my translation) defines it as “a lexical repertoire consisting of words and expressions of diverse origin, used interchangeably with standard Spanish words, and widely disseminated across all social layers and urban centers in Argentina.”

expression. For instance, the general noun *stuff* in (15) anaphorically refers to the DP *all this crockery*; the same pattern is attested in (16), where the general noun *place* allows to refer to the proper name *Geneva*.

- (15) A: What shall I do with all this crockery?
 B: Leave the stuff here; someone'll come and put it away.
- (16) Can you tell me where to stay in Geneva? I've never been to the place.

The Spanish noun *cosa* 'thing' belongs to this class as well: in most cases, it functions as a highly generalized noun that functions as a hyperonym for inanimate entities. In other words, it occupies the top level of the hyponymy hierarchy for non-animated nouns, and serves as a semantically bleached superordinate term under which more specific lexical items can be subsumed. Because of this extreme generality, *cosa* is often used in contexts where the speaker either cannot or chooses not to provide a more specific term, just like placeholders. In addition, it supports both anaphoric and vague reference. For instance, analogous examples to those found in (15) and (16) can be constructed with *cosa*.

- (17) A: Le envíe un paquete por correo a mi primo en Australia.
 3SG.DAT sent.1SG a package by mail DAT my cousin in Australia
 'I sent a package to my cousin in Australia.'
- B: ¿Y la cosa llegó bien?
 and the thing arrived.3SG well
 'And did the thing arrive safely?'
- (18) Por suerte no fuimos a la fiesta. Dicen que la cosa fue muy aburrida.
 by luck not went.1PL to the party say.3PL that the thing was very boring
 'Luckily, we didn't go to the party. They say the thing was really boring.'

In consonance with the characterization of *cosa* as a general noun, De Miguel (2025: 26) describes *cosa* as an element with scarce lexical content, i.e., a light noun. She notices that this property leads it to function as a polysemous item able to denote different types of entities depending on the predicates it combines with. Thus, for instance, in (19a) *cosa* receives the interpretation of an eventive nominal because it combines with the verb *ocurrir* 'happen', while in (19b) it is interpreted as a physical object because it combines with *regalar* 'give'.

- (19) a. Ayer ocurrió una cosa inesperada.
 yesterday happened.3SG a thing unexpected
 'An unexpected thing happened yesterday.'
- b. Me han regalado una cosa muy útil.
 1SG.DAT have.3PL given a thing very useful
 'They have given me a very useful thing.'

Since they belong to different classes, the general noun *cosa* contrasts with the nominal placeholders *coso* and *este/esta* in a number of contexts. To begin with, *cosa* typically requires further specification in order to be felicitously used as part of a DP. As shown in (20a), an NP such as *la cosa* 'the thing' may sound pragmatically odd in an unmarked context. This is because the meaning of the noun *cosa* is too general and vague to effectively identify a unique entity; that is, without additional cues, the hearer may not be able to recognize what *cosa* refers to. By contrast, when this DP contains a restrictive modifier, as

in (20b), its referent becomes easier to identify, and the utterance is felicitous. This effect does not arise with *coso* or *este/esta*, which can surface with a definite article alone, e.g., (21). This suggests that the kind of imprecision introduced by nominal placeholders differs from that of general nouns.

- (20) a. # Da-me la cosa.
give-1SG.DAT the thing
'Give me the thing.'
- b. Dame la cosa que está en el cajón.
give-1SG.DAT the thing that is.3SG in the drawer
'Give me the thing that is in the drawer.'
- (21) a. Dame el coso.
give-1SG.DAT the coso
'Give me the whatchamacallit.'
- b. Dame el este.
give-1SG.DAT the ESTE
'Give me the whatchamacallit.'

The examples in (22) allow to clarify the basis of the semantic contrast between general nouns and nominal placeholders. As can be seen, all the examples involve indefinite DPs. In (22a), the use of the word *cosa* correlates with a nonspecific interpretation, i.e., the sentence conveys that at least one entity was left on the table, without no regard to which type of entity it is. This reading is not available with the nominal placeholders in (22b) and (22c): in these cases, the sentence implies that a particular type of thing was left, even if it is being referred to in an imprecise way.⁴

- (22) a. Te dejé una cosa en la mesa.
2SG.DAT left.1SG a thing in the table
'I left a thing on the table for you.'
- b. Te dejé un coso en la mesa.
2SG.DAT left.1SG a coso in the table
'I left a whatchamacallit on the table for you.'
- c. Te dejé un este en la mesa.
2SG.DAT left.1SG a ESTE in the table
'I left a whatchamacallit on the table for you.'

⁴An anonymous reviewer suggests that *coso* might be analyzed as a classifying noun akin to *tipo* 'type', *clase* 'class', or *especie* 'species', whose contribution would be to encode uncertainty about the name of a kind. This is an intriguing idea, and it is compatible with the intuition introduced below that placeholders involve epistemic specificity targeting a predicate of type $\langle e, t \rangle$. However, treating *coso* as a classifier-like nominal is difficult to defend on syntactic grounds. First, unlike classifying nouns, *coso* does not license the *N de N* pattern associated with classifier constructions, e.g., (i). Second, *coso* itself can be embedded under a true classifying noun, e.g., (ii), which suggests that it functions as a lexical noun rather than as a classifier.

- (i) * Tengo un coso de libro.
have.1SG a coso of book
Intended: 'I have a certain kind of book.'
- (ii) No me gusta ese tipo de coso.
not 3SG.DAT like that type of coso
'I don't like that kind of thingy.'

This contrast is similar to what is often observed in cases of ambiguity with indefinite nominals. Consider the classic example in (23), taken from Fodor & Sag (1982: 355). In this sentence, the indefinite DP *a student* can receive either a specific or a nonspecific interpretation. Under the specific interpretation, the sentence refers to a particular student; a possible continuation under this reading would be *and his name is Cosmo*. Under the nonspecific interpretation, the DP has a quantificational reading; a possible continuation under this reading would be *and we don't know who he was*.

(23) A student in Syntax 1 cheated on the exam.

The specific reading of (23) arises when the speaker is certain about the identity of the referent of the indefinite DP, i.e., the specificity effect follows from having a particular entity in mind. For this reason, nominals that convey this kind of meaning are known as *epistemic specific indefinites* (Farkas 2002, Von Stechow 2002).

This type of effect is similar, though not identical, to the one obtained with nominal placeholders: when these elements are used, the speaker knows precisely what they are referring to, and even expects the hearer to identify the intended referent, despite the fact that the most appropriate lexical item has not been employed. The key difference between epistemic specific indefinites and nominal placeholders in indefinite contexts is that the epistemic specificity of the former concerns an entity, i.e., the speaker has in mind a semantic object of type $\langle e \rangle$, whereas in the latter case the epistemic specificity targets a class of entity, i.e., a semantic object of type $\langle e, t \rangle$, which is the prototypical denotation of a noun.⁵

Evidence for this characterization comes from the behavior of nominal placeholders when they are required to function as variables. As is well known, indefinite nominals can be interpreted as variables when they occur under the scope of quantificational adverbs (e.g., Heim 1982, Bosque 2001). For instance, a sentence like (24) allows an interpretation in which the adverb *siempre* ‘always’ binds the indefinite DP *una cosa* ‘a thing’; the resulting reading is that, each time, a different inanimate entity of any kind is placed there.

(24) Siempre ponen una cosa ahí.
 always put.3sg a thing there
 ‘They always put something there.’

Similar examples can be constructed with nominal placeholders, e.g., (25), although with a slight interpretive difference: the bound reading of the indefinite DP in these cases is restricted to a single type of entity. For instance, if by *cosa* or *este* the speaker is referring to a street sign, what is conveyed is that each time a different street sign is placed there. This follows from the fact that the class of entities referred to by nominal placeholders is specific at the epistemic level, i.e., the speaker has in mind a semantic object of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ that is substituted into the linguistic representation. Therefore, any potential value of the variables *un cosa* and *un este* must be restricted to entities of type $\langle e \rangle$ consistent with the corresponding $\langle e, t \rangle$ predicate.

(25) a. Siempre ponen un cosa ahí.
 always put.3sg a cosa there
 ‘They always put a whatchamacallit there.’

⁵The proposal that nominal placeholders denote $\langle e, t \rangle$ predicates differs from Seraku’s (2023) analysis, in which expressions such as English *whatchamacallit* or French *machin* are of type $\langle e \rangle$, on a par with proper names such as *Ken*. While such an approach may be appropriate for scenarios in which nominal placeholders replace proper names, e.g., (7b), it does not straightforwardly extend to cases in which the placeholder combines with a determiner or surfaces in plural form.

- b. Siempre ponen un *este* ahí.
 always put.3SG a ESTE there
 ‘They always put a whatchamacallit there.’

This aspect of the meaning of nominal placeholders is also evident in definite contexts. A definite DP built from a general noun displays different use conditions than definite DPs containing nominal placeholders. For example, the sentence in (26) introduces the presupposition that there is a unique object in the drawer. The examples in (27), by contrast, are compatible with a scenario in which there are other objects in the drawer. This difference follows from the fact that the uniqueness presupposition associated with the definite article applies in the first case to the entire set of inanimate entities, whereas in the second it is restricted to a specific type of entity.

- (26) Eliana me dio la cosa que estaba en el cajón.
 Eliana 1SG.DAT gave.3SG the thing that was.3G in the drawer
 ‘Eliana gave me the thing that was in the drawer.’
- (27) a. Eliana me dio el coso que estaba en el cajón.
 Eliana 1SG.DAT gave.3SG the coso that was.3G in the drawer
 ‘Eliana gave me the whatchamacallit that was in the drawer.’
 b. Eliana me dio el *este* que estaba en el cajón.
 Eliana 1SG.DAT gave.3SG the ESTE that was.3G in the drawer
 ‘Eliana gave me the whatchamacallit that was in the drawer.’

A final important difference between general nouns and nominal placeholders concerns their ability to denote propositional objects. As shown in (28), the DP *una cosa* can refer to the propositional content expressed in clause S. The sentences in (29), on the other hand, show that nominal placeholders cannot do so. This also follows from the fact that the epistemic specificity of these elements is restricted to predicates of type $\langle e, t \rangle$.

- (28) Prometiste una cosa_i: [_{S_i} que vendrías temprano].
 promised.2SG a thing that come.2SG early
 ‘You promised a thing: that you would come early.’
- (29) a. *Prometiste un coso_i: [_{O_i} que vendrías temprano].
 promised.2SG a coso that come.2SG early
 ‘You promised a whatchamacallit: that you would come early.’
 b. *Prometiste un *este*_i: [_{O_i} que vendrías temprano].
 promised.2SG a ESTE that come.2SG early
 ‘You promised a whatchamacallit: that you would come early.’

Summing up, the behavior of *coso* and *este/esta* cannot be reduced to the properties of superficially similar elements in the language. In particular, both elements trigger interpretations that involve epistemic specificity, a property that sets them apart from so-called general nouns such as *cosa* ‘thing’.

3 Grammatical differences between *coso* and *este*

Although the nominal placeholders *coso* and *este/esta* share several properties that set them apart from general nouns, they also exhibit a range of differential grammatical behaviors that make it impossible to

provide the same morphosyntactic treatment for them. To begin with, the inflectional paradigms of the two elements differ. When standing for inanimate entities, the Rioplatense Spanish placeholder *coso* is an inherently masculine noun that can be pluralized.

- (30) a. Se rompió el coso.
 SE broke.3SG the.MASC.SG COSO.SG
 ‘The whatchamacallit broke.’
 b. Se rompieron los cosos.
 SE broke.3PL the.MASC.PL COSO.PL
 ‘The whatchamacallits broke.’

By contrast, *este/esta* in Chilean Spanish inflects for gender, while its plural forms are somewhat marked (though still acceptable) for speakers of the dialect.⁶

- (31) a. Se rompió el este.
 SE broke.3SG the.MASC.SG ESTE.MASC.SG
 ‘The whatchamacallit broke.’
 b. Se rompió la esta.
 SE broke.3SG the.FEM.SG ESTE.FEM.SG
 ‘The whatchamacallit broke.’
 c. ? Se rompieron los estos.
 SE broke.3PL the.MASC.PL ESTE.MASC.PL
 ‘The whatchamacallits broke.’
 d. ? Se rompieron las estas.
 SE broke.3PL the.FEM.PL ESTE.FEM.PL
 ‘The whatchamacallits broke.’

In most cases, the gender of *este/esta* does not seem to introduce interpretive differences. For instance, the sentence pairs in (32) and (33) are completely interchangeable when the referent of the nominal placeholder is an inanimate entity.

- (32) a. Pása-me el este que dejé ahí.
 pass.2SG-me the.MASC ESTE.MASC that left.1SG there
 ‘Pass me the whatchamacallit I left there.’
 b. Pásame la esta que dejé ahí.
 pass.2SG-me the.FEM ESTE.FEM that left.1SG there
 ‘Pass me the whatchamacallit I left there.’
 (33) a. Pásame el este que está en la esta.
 pass.2SG-me the.MASC ESTE.MASC that left.1SG in the.FEM ESTE.FEM
 ‘Pass me the whatchamacallit I left in the thingy.’
 b. Pásame la esta que está en el este.
 pass.2SG-me the.FEM ESTE.FEM that left.1SG in the.MASC ESTE.MASC
 ‘Pass me the whatchamacallit I left in the thingy.’

⁶Magdalena Covarrubias (p.c.) reports that the neuter pronoun *esto* appears as a nominal placeholder in several examples from the *Sociolinguistic Speech Corpus of Chilean Spanish* (Sadovsky 2022), in exactly the same way illustrated in example (5) for Peruvian Spanish. However, both my informants and the Chilean linguists I consulted reject these uses outright. I can only assume that the data collected by Covarrubias correspond to a different variety.

Although some speakers report the intuition that *este* and *esta* should substitute for masculine and feminine nouns, respectively, they also admit that this is not necessary for effective communication. Thus, the dialogue in (34) is perceived as perfectly natural.

- (34) A: Oye, pásame la esta.
 hey pass.2SG-me the.FEM ESTE.FEM
 ‘Hey, pass me the whatchamacallit.’
 B: ¿El alicate?
 the.MASC pliers.MASC
 The pliers?
 A: Sí.
 yes
 ‘Yes.’

The only scenarios in which the gender of the nominal placeholder *este/esta* is relevant for the acceptability of the utterance are those where the biological sex of the referent is salient, e.g., with humans or animals that display an obvious sexual dimorphism.

Both *coso* and *este/esta* can also substitute for proper names. In these cases, a slight difference in meaning arises compared to contexts where a common noun is replaced: since the speaker has a specific entity in mind, rather than a class of entities, the epistemic specificity of nominal placeholders applies to semantic objects of type <*e*>. Thus, for instance, the sentences in (35) presuppose familiarity with the referents of each placeholder.

- (35) a. Coso dijo eso.
 coso said.3SG that
 ‘Whatchamacallit said that.’
 b. El este dijo eso.
 The.MASC ESTE.MASC said.3SG that
 ‘Whatchamacallit (a male) said that.’

While the placeholder *coso* does not display gender morphology, it can substitute for proper names corresponding to entities of any sex. Thus, the sentence in (35a) is acceptable whether *coso* refers to a man or to a woman. The behavior of *este/esta*, by contrast, differs in this respect: when referring to female entities, this element must bear feminine gender inflection.

- (36) La esta dijo eso.
 The.FEM ESTE.FEM said.3SG that
 ‘Whatchamacallit (a female) said that.’

An important difference that emerges between the two placeholders when they replace proper names concerns the presence and obligatoriness of determiners. In Rioplatense Spanish, *coso* rejects the presence of determiners when it substitutes for a proper name, e.g., (37a). This correlates with the usual behavior of anthroponyms in this dialect: they generally reject the presence of the definite determiner (De Mello 1992), e.g., (37b).

- (37) a. *El Coso dijo eso.
 The coso said.3SG that

‘The whatchamacallit said that.’

- b. * El Jorge dijo eso.
The Jorge said.3SG that
‘The Jorge said that.’

By contrast, as shown in the examples in (35b) and (36), the forms *este/esta* do appear with determiners when they substitute for a proper name. This correlates with the widespread use of definite articles with anthroponyms in Chilean Spanish (De Mello 1992). As Oroz (1966: 371) observes, this pattern represents the norm in Chilean Spanish: although the variety displays optionality in the use of definite articles with human proper names, e.g., (38) and (39), the variant with the article is more frequent and more natural in colloquial speech (Muñoz Pérez 2026).

- (38) a. El Jorge dijo eso.
The Jorge said.3SG that
‘The Jorge said that.’
b. La Eliana dijo eso.
The Eliana said.3SG that
‘The Eliana said that.’
(39) a. Jorge dijo eso.
Jorge said.3SG that
‘Jorge said that.’
b. Eliana dijo eso.
Eliana said.3SG that
‘Eliana said that.’

This optionality, however, is not observed with the forms *este/esta* when they substitute for a proper name. As already noted, without the determiner these elements can only function as ordinary demonstrative pronouns.

- (40) a. * Este dijo eso.
this.MASC said.3SG that
‘Whatchamacallit said that’. *placeholder reading*
b. * Esta dijo eso.
this.FEM said.3SG that
‘Whatchamacallit said that’. *placeholder reading*

A particularly strong contrast between *coso* and *este/esta* is that only the former accepts derivational processes characteristic of the nominal class. Thus, it is possible to form diminutives with *coso*, e.g., (41a), but not with *este/esta*, e.g., (41b) and (41c).

- (41) a. el cos-ito
the coso-DIM
‘the little whatchamacallit’
b. * el este-cito
the ESTE-DIM
‘the little whatchamacallit’

These placeholders also display distributional differences: only *coso* can co-occur with demonstratives. As the data in (42) show, a demonstrative modifier such as *ese* ‘that’ can either precede or follow the placeholder *coso*. The form *este/esta*, by contrast, rejects the presence of such an element regardless of its position within the DP, e.g., (43).

- (42) a. Compramos *ese* *coso*.
 buy.1PL that *coso*
 ‘Let’s buy that whatchamacallit.’
 b. Compramos *el* *coso* *ese*.
 buy.1PL the *coso* that
 ‘Let’s buy that whatchamacallit.’
- (43) a. *Compramos *ese* *este*.
 buy.1PL that *ESTE*
 ‘Let’s buy that whatchamacallit.’
 b. *Compramos *el* *este* *ese*.
 buy.1PL the *ESTE* that
 ‘Let’s buy that whatchamacallit.’

This type of contrast is not observed with other elements that can occupy prenominal or postnominal positions within the DP. For example, both *coso* and *este/esta* can co-occur with possessive modifiers such as *tu/tuyo* ‘your’, e.g., (44) and (45).

- (44) a. Traé *tu* *coso*.
 bring.2SG your *coso*
 ‘Bring your whatchamacallit.’
 b. Traé *el* *coso* *tuyo*.
 bring.2SG the *coso* your
 ‘Bring the whatchamacallit of yours.’
- (45) a. Trae *tu* *este*.
 bring.2SG your *ESTE*
 ‘Bring your whatchamacallit.’
 b. Trae *el* *este* *tuyo*.
 bring.2SG the *coso* your
 ‘Bring the whatchamacallit of yours.’

A final relevant grammatical property of these elements concerns their ability to combine with adjectives: both must obligatorily precede the adjective that accompanies them. Thus, in the examples in (46) and (47), we see that both *coso* and *este/esta* can be followed by an adjective “to their right.”

- (46) a. No encuentro *el* *coso* nuevo.
 not find.1SG the *coso* new
 ‘I can’t find the new whatchamacallit.’
 b. Pasa-me *el* *coso* pequeño.
 pass-me the *coso* little
 ‘Pass me the little whatchamacallit.’

- (47) a. No encuentro el este nuevo.
not find.1SG the ESTE new
'I can't find the new whatchamacallit.'
- b. Pásame el este pequeño.
pass-me the ESTE little
'Pass me the little whatchamacallit.'

However, both elements reject the pattern in which they are preceded by an adjective.

- (48) a. *No encuentro el nuevo coso
not find.1SG the new coso
'I can't find the new whatchamacallit.'
- b. *Pasame el pequeño coso.
pass-me the little coso
'Pass me the little whatchamacallit.'
- (49) a. *No encuentro el nuevo este.
not find.1SG the new ESTE
'I can't find the new whatchamacallit.'
- b. *Pásame el pequeño este.
pass-me the little ESTE
'Pass me the little whatchamacallit.'

Summing up, this section examined various morphosyntactic properties of the nominal placeholders *coso* and *este/esta*. In particular, the analysis focused on: (i) their ability to inflect for gender; (ii) the possibility (or requirement) of using a definite article when substituting for a proper name (PN); (iii) their compatibility with diminutive derivational morphology; (iv) their ability to co-occur with demonstrative or possessive modifiers; and (v) their compatibility with adjectival modifiers, as well as the position of these with respect to the placeholder. The table below provides a summary of the properties discussed.

Property	<i>coso</i>	<i>este/esta</i>	
inflects for gender	X	✓	see (30) to (34)
determiner in PN context	X	✓	see (35) to (40)
nominal morphology (diminutives)	✓	X	see (41)
co-occurs with demonstratives	✓	X	see (42) and (43)
co-occurs with possessives	✓	✓	see (44) and (45)
adjective after	✓	✓	see (46) and (47)
adjective before	X	X	see (48) and (49)

Table 1: Comparison of properties of *coso* and *este/esta*

In the next section, I provide a preliminary syntactic analysis of nominal placeholders connecting these properties.

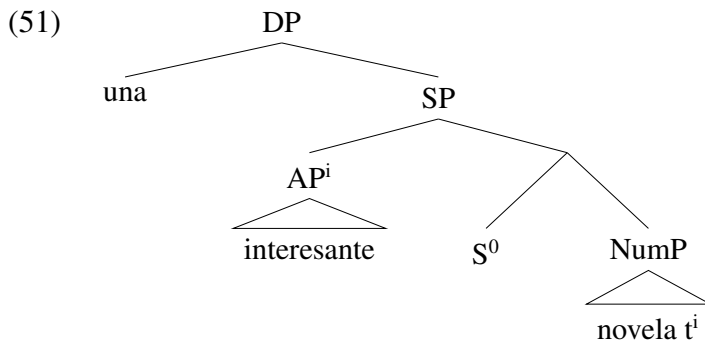
4 Toward an analysis of nominal placeholders

As discussed in section 2, both *coso* and *este/esta* exhibit epistemic specificity with respect to a class of entities. Since this property is shared by both elements, any analysis proposed for them must include common components capable of capturing this characteristic.

To this end, I propose that the syntax of nominal placeholders in general recruits a specificity head S^0 , located at the left periphery of the DP, between the position of the determiner and the number projection; see Cornilescu & Nicolae (2016), Fábregas (2019), and Konan & Puskas (2021), among others, for similar proposals. I will assume that the functional projection headed by this head is responsible for contrasts such as the one illustrated in (50). As can be seen, the postnominal placement of the adjective *interesante* ‘interesting’ in (50a) allows for both specific and nonspecific interpretations of the nominal: under the specific reading, the speaker knows which interesting novel they want to read; under the nonspecific reading, the speaker merely asserts wanting to read some interesting novel, without regard to which one. By contrast, if the adjective *interesante* is prenominal, as in (50b), only the specific interpretation is available.

- (50) a. Quiero leer una novela interesante.
 want.1sg to.read a novel interesting
 ‘I want to read an interesting novel.’ specific ✓, nonspecific ✓
- b. Quiero leer una interesante novela.
 want.1sg to.read a interesting novel
 ‘I want to read an interesting novel.’ specific ✓, nonspecific ✗

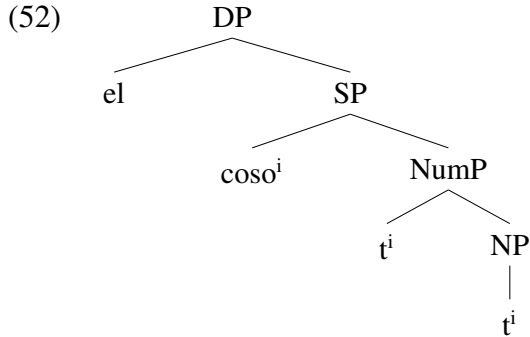
The correlation between the specific interpretation of the nominal and the prenominal position of the adjective can be accounted for by means of the specificity projection just mentioned. That is, the structure of (50b) would involve movement of the adjective *interesante* ‘interesting’ to the specifier position of the head S^0 . By hypothesis, this head activates specific interpretations when some constituent moves into its domain. A sketch of the proposed structure is given in (51).



I propose that structures receiving a nominal placeholder interpretation systematically interact with the head S^0 through overt movement; that is, some constituent with phonological realization must move into the domain of the phrase headed by S^0 . In this way, structures with nominal placeholders always receive a specific interpretation. I further assume that once a constituent moves into the domain of S^0 , this projection becomes syntactically inert, i.e., it can no longer attract further elements.

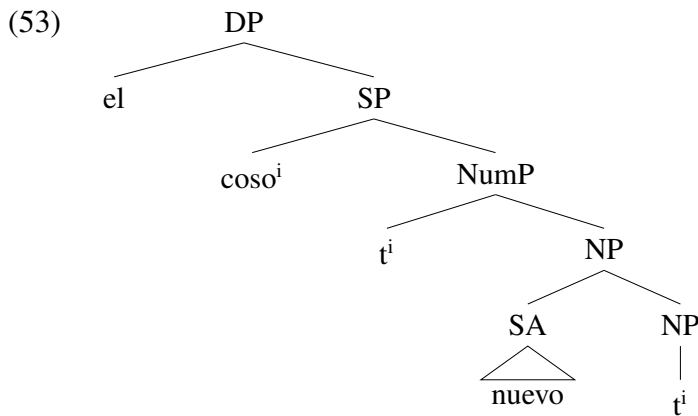
I begin by showing how this idea works for the Rioplatense Spanish placeholder *coso*. I argue that this element enters the syntax as a nominal head, i.e., *coso* is a noun; evidence for this is that it admits nominal

derivational morphology such as diminutives, e.g., (41a). Nouns are typically assumed to undergo head movement to the functional projection NumP, where the number affixes are introduced. For the nominal structure to acquire the specific interpretation characteristic of a placeholder, I contend that *coso* moves via head movement to S^0 , passing through Num⁰ on the way. The tree diagram in (52) illustrates the derivation of the DP *el coso* ‘the whatchamacallit’.



The basic intuition captured by this scheme is that *coso* has the basic syntactic functioning of a noun, but adds to it a specificity component.

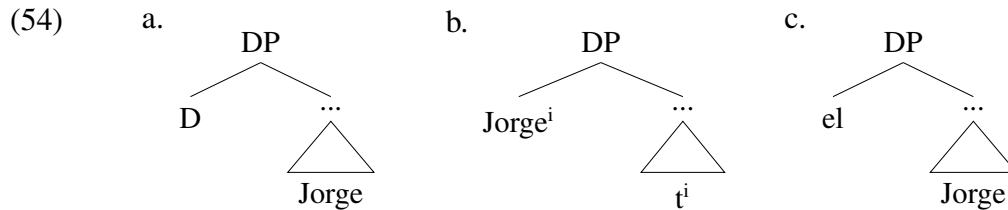
The distribution of *coso* with respect to adjectives can be explained on the basis of this underlying structure. As shown earlier, *coso* may precede an adjective, e.g., (46), but it cannot appear after an adjective, e.g., (48). To account for this restriction, I assume that adjectives are base-generated in a prenominal position, and that their unmarked postnominal order results from systematic movement of the head N^0 to the number head Num⁰ (e.g., Bernstein 1993). In cases where the nominal head is *coso*, the derivation proposed above is extended with movement of this element to the specificity head S^0 . The representation in (53) illustrates these steps and schematizes the structure of the DP corresponding to the sentence in (46a).



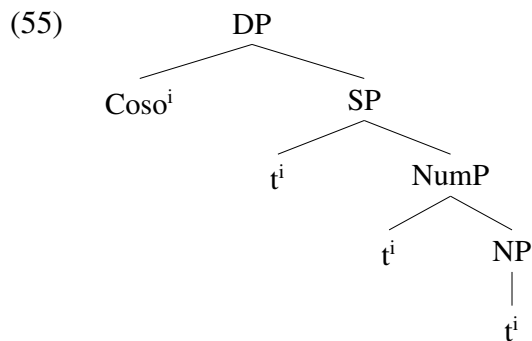
This structure also accounts for why an adjective cannot precede *coso*. To derive the ungrammatical order illustrated in (48a), the AP in (52) would need to move to the specifier position of the specificity phrase [Spec,SP]. However, this is not possible because the noun *coso* has already moved into that domain and, by hypothesis, this syntactically deactivates the projection. It therefore follows that *coso* cannot be preceded by adjectives.

The basic structure in (52) also explains why *coso* rejects the presence of definite determiners when it substitutes for a human proper name. For this, I draw on the influential analysis of proper names by

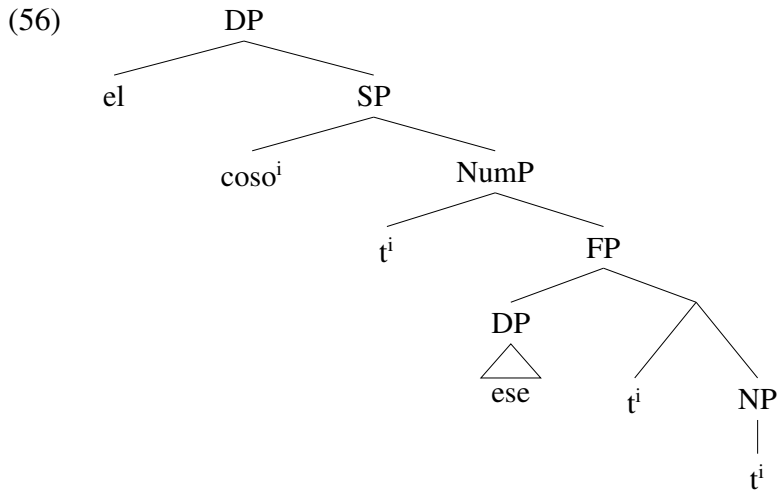
Longobardi (1994). According to this author, a proper name is part of a nominal structure headed by a definite determiner, e.g., (54a). The reason why this determiner remains silent in many languages is that the noun incorporates into D via head movement, e.g., (54b). Some languages, however, allow the option of not moving the N head into D; in such cases, the D head surfaces as an expletive definite determiner, e.g., (54c).



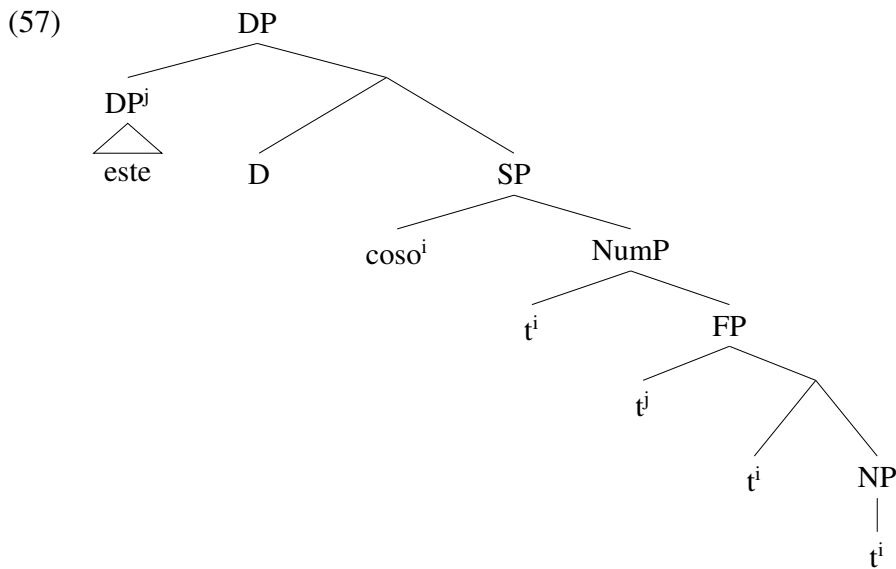
As shown in the example in (37b), Rioplatense Spanish generally does not allow the use of definite determiners with anthroponyms. This indicates that the variety employs the derivation in (54b) rather than that in (54c). Under the assumption that *coso* behaves syntactically like a proper name when it substitutes for one, I propose that *coso* raises to D, in line with the derivation in (54b). This blocks the possibility of a definite determiner co-occurring with *coso*. The syntactic representation in (55) illustrates the proposal.



Finally, I turn to the distribution of *coso* with respect to modifiers within the DP. I begin with demonstratives, which can combine with *coso* in any position, e.g., (42). I adopt an analysis along the lines of Brugè (1996, 2002). According to this author, demonstratives are base-generated as specifiers of a functional head F^0 that combines with the NP. The postnominal position of the demonstrative (e.g., *el libro ese* ‘that book’) follows from N^0 moving to an intermediate functional head within the nominal projection; here I assume that this projection is NumP. Given that the placeholder *coso* is proposed to move to S^0 passing through Num^0 and other heads, the representation in (56) illustrates the structure of the DP in (42b).



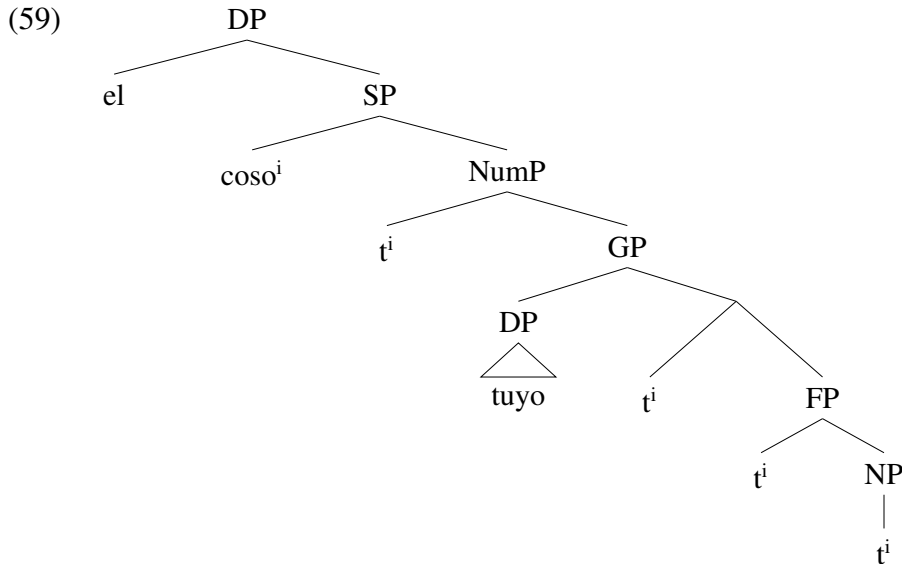
According to Brughè, when the DP is headed by a demonstrative (e.g., *ese libro* ‘that book’), this element must have moved to the specifier position of the D^0 , which remains silent under a logic similar to that of the *Generalized Doubly Filled Comp Filter* (Koopman & Szabolcsi 2000: 4). In this way, the grammaticality of the nominal in the sentence in (42a) is accounted for. The corresponding syntactic representation is given in (57).



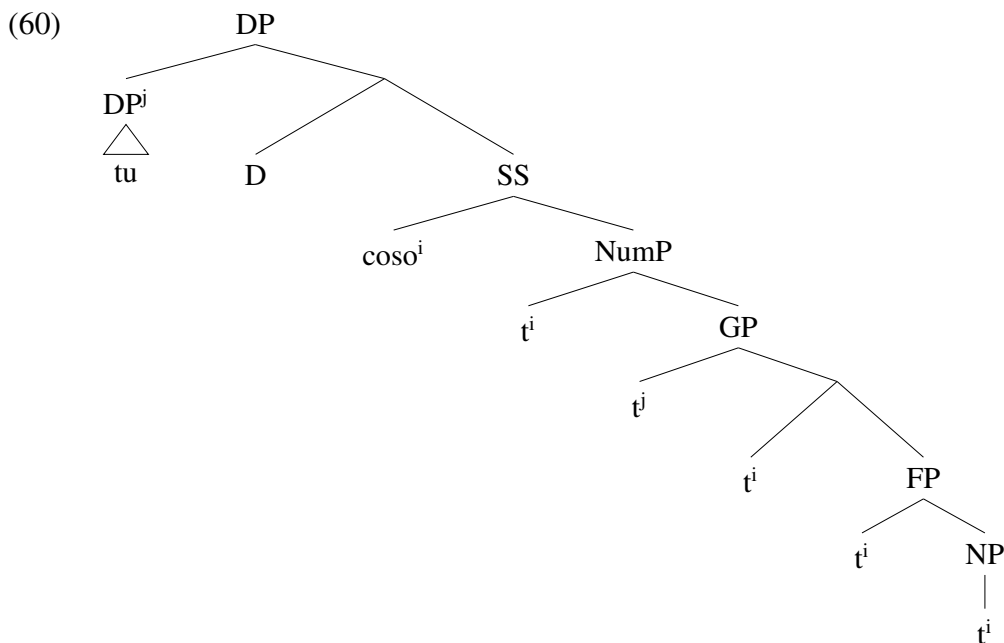
I will adopt a similar treatment for possessive modifiers: I tentatively assume that they are base-generated as specifiers of a GP projection immediately above the FP layer of demonstratives. The main reason for distinguishing the merge position of these two types of modifiers is that they can co-occur within the same DP, e.g., (58).

- (58)
- a. *este libro suyo*
this book poss.3
‘this book of his/hers’
 - b. *el libro tuyo ese*
the book your that
‘that book of yours’

The postnominal position of the possessive (e.g., *el libro tuyo* ‘the book of yours’) would likewise result from head movement of N^0 into Num^0 . As already discussed, *coso* follows this derivation and, in addition, moves to the specificity head. In this way, it is predicted that *coso* can co-occur with possessives that follow it in linear order. The structure corresponding to the nominal in the example in (44b) is sketched in (59).



As with demonstratives, prenominal possessives move to the specifier position of the DP. Since the structure in (59) makes this derivational step available, it is predicted that *coso* can also co-occur with possessive modifiers that precede it. As an illustration, the structure corresponding to the nominal in the sentence in (44a) is sketched in (60).



Having presented the analysis of the phenomena associated with *coso*, I now turn to the differences exhibited by *este/esta* in Chilean Spanish. As will be shown, the behavior of this element can be derived

from the same set of assumptions outlined so far. The main difference lies in the characterization proposed for *este/esta*.

My proposal is far from surprising. I argue that *este/esta* is not a noun, but rather a demonstrative modifier merged in the FP projection in line with the analysis of Brugè (1996, 2002); this is consistent with the fact that this element does not admit nominal diminutive morphology, e.g., (41b) and (41c). Instead, I contend that it is an empty noun *e* that occupies the head position of the NP, i.e., the “true” nominal placeholder in the construction is a syntactic object without phonological realization. Under this approach, the demonstrative surfacing in the placeholder configuration may be taken to license the empty noun *e* and to identify it via agreement, in a way that is reminiscent of Rizzi’s (1986) proposal for the null pronominal *pro*.

An analysis on these lines equates the functioning of the placeholder *este/esta* with well-known cases in Spanish in which a modifier seemingly functions as a nominal head, e.g., (61a), as well as with other scenarios in which there appears to be a missing nominal element, e.g., (61b) and (61c).⁷

- (61) a. el tonto
the idiot
‘the idiot’
b. las de al lado
the of to.the side
‘the ones next door’
c. los que protestan
the that protest
‘those who protest’

Examples like these have been argued to involve a phonologically empty noun *e* with a human-denoting interpretation (e.g., Panagiotidis 2002, Kornfeld & Saab 2004). The relevant analysis is sketched in (62).

- (62) a. [DP el *e* tonto]
b. [DP las *e* de al lado]
c. [DP los *e* que protestan]

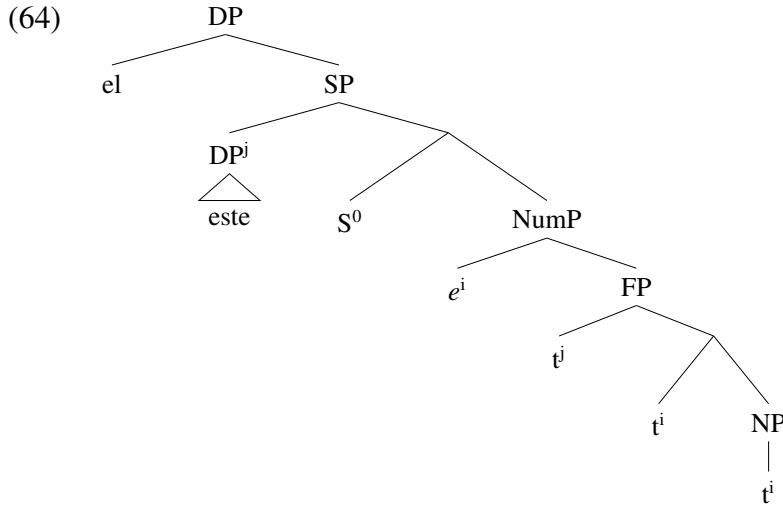
As shown in (63), I take it that the *este/esta* can receive a parallel treatment, although with an important caveat: the type of empty noun found in placeholder constructions must be different from the one advanced for examples such as (62). There are two main reasons for this. First, the placeholder construction in Chilean Spanish is not restricted to human referents; arguably, the type of empty noun depicted in (63) must have a more general meaning akin to *whatchamacallit*, *machin*, *Dingsbums* or *coso*. Second, if the type of empty noun found in (62) and (63) was the same, one would expect the placeholder *este/esta* to be attested broadly in Spanish, which is not the case; thus, the type of empty noun sketched in (63) must be treated as an item found only in the Chilean Spanish lexicon.

- (63) a. [DP el *e* este]
b. [DP la *e* esta]

⁷An analysis in terms of an empty noun should not be equated with one involving ellipsis. See Saab (2008, 2019) for a systematic comparison.

By hypothesis, the empty noun *e* behaves like an ordinary nominal head: on the one hand, it can bear either masculine or feminine gender, similar to the pair *niño/niña* ‘boy/girl’; on the other, it incorporates into Num⁰ in the underlying syntactic structure. It follows that *e* governs agreement relations within the DP with adjectives, articles and, more importantly, demonstratives. Thus, the gender alternation between *el este* and *la esta* derives directly from the inflectional properties of *e*.

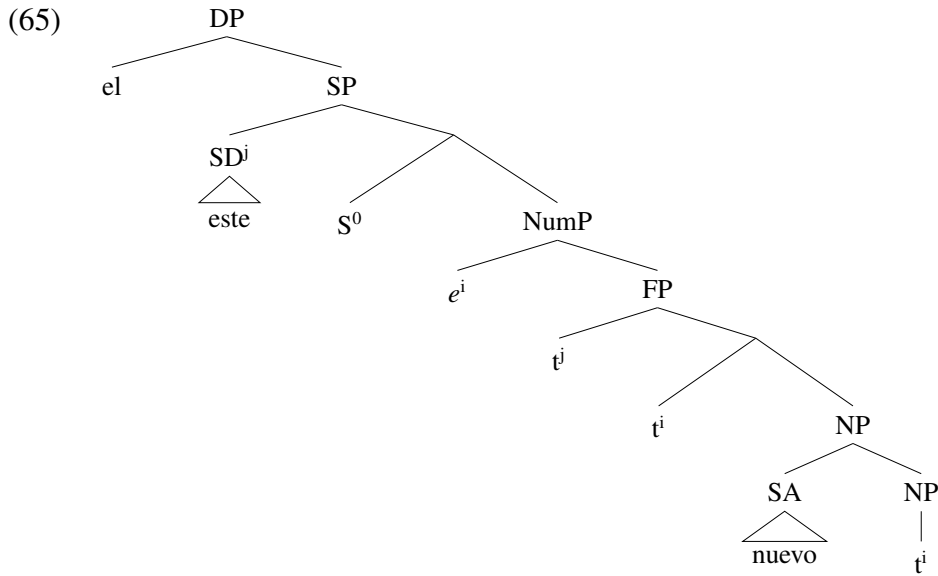
When the nominal placeholder structure is built around the empty noun *e*, it is the demonstrative modifier that moves to the specifier of the specificity projection. This follows from the assumption that movement into this domain must be overt, a condition not satisfied by the raising of *e* to S⁰. Accordingly, the analysis proposed for the definite nominal *el este* corresponds to the representation in (64).



The idea that the nominal head is null makes it possible to explain the behavior of the placeholder *este/esta* in contexts where it substitutes for a human proper name. As discussed with the examples in (38) and (39), the presence of the definite determiner is optional with anthroponyms in Chilean Spanish. This shows that the variety allows both derivational alternatives in (54b) and (54c). Thus, the obligatoriness of the definite determiner when *este/esta* substitutes for a human proper name is, at first sight, puzzling, since both options should in principle be available here as well. This problem is resolved under the proposed analysis. Since the head *e* is phonologically empty, its raising to D⁰ should have no phonological effect. Therefore, even if the derivational alternative in (54b) applies, the determiner head must surface with expletive pronunciation. In other words, the null character of the nominal head renders the surface output of the derivational alternatives in (54a) and (54b) indistinguishable.⁸

The structure in (64) also predicts that the placeholder *este/esta* may precede an adjective, e.g., (47). This follows from the fact that adjectives combine with the NP and therefore occupy a position “to the right” of the demonstrative after it moved to the specificity projection. The structure in (65) illustrates this for the DP in example (47a).

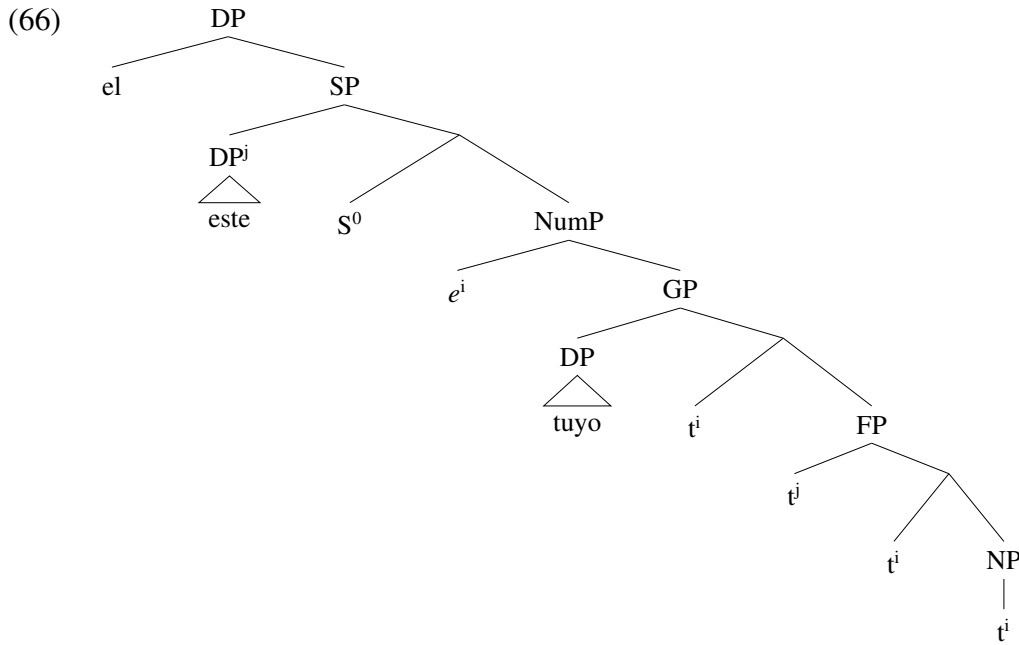
⁸Another way of explaining the obligatoriness of the definite determiner in these contexts appeals to locality principles governing head movement. As shown in (64), the head S⁰ intervenes between D⁰ and *e*. Since *e* cannot raise to S⁰ due to the syntactic inactivity of the latter, it follows that movement of *e* to D⁰ is impossible. As a consequence, the derivational alternative in (54b) should be ruled out, leaving (54c) as the only viable option for generating a proper name structure with the nominal placeholder.



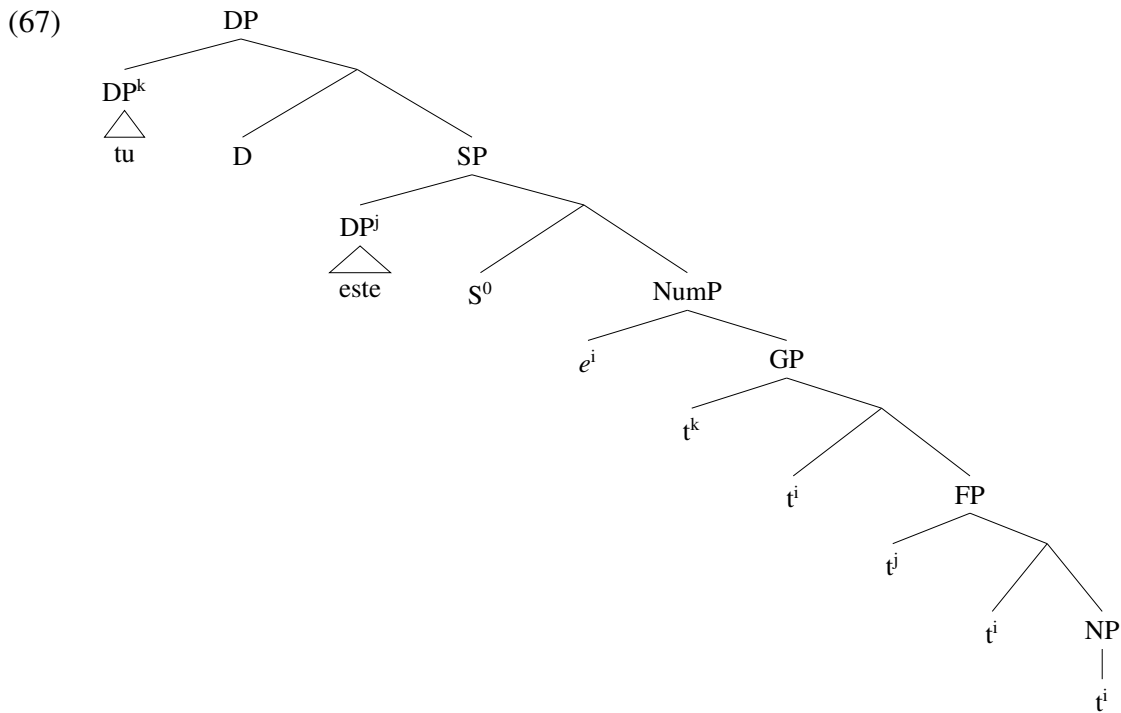
Moreover, this representation correctly predicts that *este* cannot appear preceded by an adjective, e.g., (49). For this to be possible, the AP would need to move to the specifier position of SP. However, this is not possible because, by hypothesis, the specificity projection becomes syntactically inactive once *este* has raised.

Finally, the proposed analysis of *este/esta* directly explains why this element cannot co-occur with other demonstrative modifiers, e.g., (43). Since *este/esta* is itself a demonstrative, it follows that another constituent of the same type cannot be inserted within the same nominal structure. The representation in (64) illustrates this restriction by showing that the position where demonstratives are generated, i.e., the specifier of FP, is already occupied by the trace of *este*.

As shown in the sentences in (45), however, the restriction preventing *este/esta* from co-occurring with other demonstratives does not apply to possessive modifiers, which can appear either “to the right” or “to the left” of this element. This also follows from the assumptions adopted in this section: since demonstrative and possessive modifiers are generated in distinct syntactic projections, they are expected to be able to co-occur. The representation in (66) shows the structure of the nominal in (45b), where the possessive remains in its base position and surfaces after *este*.



On the other hand, (67) represents the structure of the nominal in (45a), where the possessive moves to the specifier position of the DP and therefore precedes *este*.



The analysis developed in this section not only captures the contrasting grammatical behavior of the nominal placeholders under study, but also suggests an important generalization regarding the nature of these elements. The behavior of nominal placeholders cannot be reduced to the lexical properties of a nominal head; rather, it depends on an intricate network of syntactic relations, some of which may remain covert. These relations are not identical across all nominal placeholders. On the contrary, they exhibit a certain degree of variation that determines differences in their combinatory properties.

5 Concluding remarks

This article has examined the grammatical properties of two types of nominal placeholders in Latin American Spanish that, until now, had not been documented in detail in the literature: the expression *coso*, characteristic of Rioplatense Spanish, and the form *este/esta*, characteristic of Chilean Spanish.

First, it was shown that the behavior of *coso* and *este/esta* cannot be reduced to the properties of superficially similar elements in General Spanish. In particular, both elements give rise to interpretations involving epistemic specificity, a feature that sets them apart from general nouns and underscores their distinctive role in the linguistic system.

Second, it was shown that these elements contrast at the grammatical level with respect to several properties, e.g., their ability (or inability) to inflect for gender, the requirement to employ a definite article when substituting for a proper name, their compatibility with diminutive derivational morphology, and their ability to co-occur with demonstrative modifiers.

To account for these differences, an analysis was proposed in which *coso* is treated as a noun that incorporates into a specificity projection within the nominal structure, whereas *este/esta* is analyzed as a demonstrative modifier that moves into this projection and accompanies a phonologically empty noun. This proposal not only accounts for the particular properties of both placeholders, but also shows that the behavior of nominal placeholders in general cannot be understood solely in terms of their lexical properties; rather, it must also take into account the syntactic structures that underlie them.

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